Shower Thought

Buddhist cosmology, as described in the Sutta Pitaka of the Theravada Pali Canon, stratifies thirty-one different planes of existence in which rebirth takes place; Hinduism assigns fourteen, seven upper and seven lower planes. Perhaps more attuned to modern sensibilities, of which includes the expectation of infinity, the modern spiritualist ascertains that our reality exists as one among many equally valid existences. A simple exercise to access these realities is as follows:

Sit beneath the shower head, any brand will do, and turn the knobs until the water is comfortable, vaguely steamy—though not too hot!—and all-consuming. A sauna may also work.

Massage your scalp in deep, lazy ovals. Let the water slip between your fingers, and land like the gentlest hail. Interpret the world through touch, in which there is only volume, pattern, pressure. Appreciate that touch has its own kind of warmth which can be felt through anything. Trace each shiver of joy. Pleasure pools at the base of your spine, running up and down, going a little further each time. Reaching your shoulder blades, the nape of your neck, below your jaw.

Tilt your head back and forth without interruption, smoothly. As you do, notice how the water and the feelings of your hands move on a shared point; overlapping like glass, joining faintness to fullness; creating, not a feeling, but a spectrum, so that the space above your head grows to contain all things. You may be surprised at how light it all is, this point of everything. It rests on your head like a feather, tickling you hilarious with possibility.

The pleasure has now reached your head. You go numb so that you don't know where *you* ends. Your brain, brimming with energy, leaps through where you once felt your skull, and for a blinding instant, joins in the point of infinity above.

For a time, you will exist in white-hot everything. Seeing all things at once is unsurprisingly similar to seeing nothing at all. With no point of reference, there is nothing to distinguish one thing from another. This experience is temporary, and safe, as proved by Orejón's theorem.

Before this technique was attempted, popular opinion among the coffeehouses of Prague and Vienna was that by entering a point of everything, the mind would surely scatter or be driven insane. Orejón's theorem, a theorem interestingly named not after a person, but a tribe from the elevated floodplains of northern Peru, was transcribed by a renounced Franciscan missionary and mathematician into the now pertinent deduction: a point containing everything must, by necessity, include a perfect copy of you. It follows then that the experience must be safe, or the other you, subject to the same laws, would surely perish. It also follows that a point that contains everything—yourself included—cannot contain any more, and so as quickly as you crashed into it, you bounce back out.

Returning to your senses, the first thing you will notice is that you are standing in the shadow of a wall many times your height. Its bricks are the orange of a heated kiln, there are no cracks between them. There is a wall like this on the edge of each province. Beyond it, from a place you cannot see, you can hear a note shared by crickets and birdsong.

You must enter through the gate. At the gate sits a guard who will ask you your name. Give it to him. Yawning, he will unroll a sprawling, stapled scroll which has written on it the name of every man or woman who is still remembered somewhere. The chairs are there for you to sit; finding your name will take some time, though will be surprisingly quick all things considered. There is little to rest your eyes on as you wait besides the lowcut grass and the road behind you. Behind where the serious-faced guard peers through his reading glasses, rushed

attendants hurry to and from the guard house, frantically adding new names or sheafs to the ever-expanding list and cutting out with scissors and carrying away the names of the departed. After some time the guard will clear his throat, address you with a "right this way mister (or missus)," and gesture with a hand to the great polished gates which swing inwards to greet you.

You have been granted entry into one of the many territories of the Border Princes. Passing through the gates reveals the rolling hills of a pastoral dream. A carriage awaits, its steps are steep but the driver extends a broad arm, hoisting you inside so that the chassis rocks a little before coming to rest. With the snap of the reins, you are taken through the winding meadows and small rustic villages. The grass is indistinguishable from flattened jade. The growers of lilac, larkspur, and daffodils are treated as essential as the farmers and shepherds, and the scent of flowers is like a second breeze. In each village, there is a beautiful blacksmith's daughter, and a quiet courageous stable hand that brings flowers for her hair; an old vicar; a mean widow whose door the children dare each other to knock on then run away laughing; many children to do so, and others who bake her lemon bread and cakes, smiling apologetically; a friendly dog; a cheerful town drunk.

The roads are long, designed not for directness but for their aesthetic value; they traverse the land with the thoroughness with which you might memorize the creases in your palm (pruney but now, I'm sure). The cart sashays and bounces, fluttering your eyes and unworking deep, hidden knots from your back. As you approach the palace you realize that all this pales in comparison. Once, in a chance encounter at a train station, a fellow traveler described it to me as what we imagine our minds see when we know we are asleep.

This time, no gates. From the trellises, banners like feisty blue jays. A procession of greeters waits along the sweeping stone promenade, ready to receive you like valets. Yours is not

the only carriage that is arriving, and a greeter will break off from the rest and ask you how you enjoyed their fair countryside; and, to your response, will smile and laugh and compliment you, shouting, “How true! How true!”

Clasping your back with a gloved hand, they will guide you through the entranceway, to hall, to room after room after room. Large chandeliers cast the rooms in fuzzy golds and passionate reds. Your feet will sink ankle-deep into the lolling crimson of the carpet, and with an “oh dear” your guide will show you to the dressing rooms of the court where all wonders of fabrics and resplendent, drooping silks rest on silver hangers. From beneath a cubby, he will withdraw a pair of cedarwood snowshoes. Presenting them like a bottle of champagne, he will explain how they have just been sweeping the court for their convenience in travel and a certain *je ne sais quoi*. He will take you through the great raised chambers with arched ceilings and generous windows which make the whole room feel as if it is floating off the ground. Looking outside, you wonder how you’d previously been so overwhelmed by the relative tameness of the countryside.

And all the while, he will tell you of the prince who rules this land: his favorite pastimes, tastes, significant life moments, recent happenings (a lover he spurned, or perhaps three successive bullseyes in a game of darts), etc. – fawning over him until they look about ready to trip over.

No one here works in servitude, your guide explains. Each and every position is taken up willingly, assigned by the prince based on favor and merit. No law compels them to keep their post, he says, for the princedom of the Border Prince is a sovereignty built upon self-governance. Like this the province operates—down from the lowly street sweep, up to advisors of art and commerce. The servant, for his part, will explain how truly blessed he is to be a servant. When

the court is in session, only they are allowed to sit at the foot of the throne, closest to the prince. If they are like the other servants, they will have attended to their prince for years, waiting on a change in favor, whispering his name as they drift off to sleep.

In reality, there are no natives in the land except the princes themselves, for all the courtiers are visitors like you, who have elected to stay. For all their lavish praises, they are transients loyal only to the prince with the most favorable arrangement. This fact is not hidden, but social custom: a dissatisfied courtier who believes in more will leave the court unimpeded and wander on to the next prince who will welcome him with open arms. Bidding you farewell in the gold-leaf antechamber of the Hall of Great Festivities, your guide will leave you with these final words. Only the prince is the true servant within his lands, and for that we make him ruler of our hearts.

Oh what a rush! The ball at the heart of the palace can go on for days; and revelers tired of dancing or feasting repose in velvet chaise lounges, or retire upstairs to more private suites. Incense, rose-petals, and perfume intoxicate the air. As many as twelve bands occupy the room, competing for your attention. Rather than pressing up close to your favorite, try standing at different distances apart from each, discovering at which point the music combines and takes on new meaning.

Within this hall there exists pleasure in all of its forms. Perhaps, you are drawn towards the woman in the giraffe coat, who invites you to dance with her upon one of the tables. Or perhaps you will find yourself among the starched collars and cable knit sweaters of stern-faced men and women, speaking loudly of politics and the world of forms. If, caught among the ducking and weaving of the quick footed players engaged in one of their many simultaneous party games, you wish to join them, you may do so too. Often, these games overlap so that new

rules must be made. (There is a game within the gardens, that I myself am very fond of, in which croquet players leapfrog over each other.) Sometimes, great golden mirrors are arranged on every wall so that the revelers' mirth extends into infinity.

In the center of the hall, high up on the dais, sits the throne of the prince. When it is occupied, it is surrounded by swooning courtiers; when it is empty—for the prince enjoys the breadth of his domain—rosy-cheeked drunks sit kissing on each other's laps.

Today, perhaps, you are lucky. One of the messengers had reached the prince from deep within the checkerboard gardens, and so he beckons you from his place on the throne. As you approach, he stands up to greet you. He is tall and broad-shouldered, his hair greying like precious stones. Or, he is slim and lithe, with teeth as sly as a fox. He hunches his shoulders a little when he talks, as if in spite of himself.

"We rarely get visitors from so far away," he says, extending his arm (I do not know whether this is true). His handshake feels simultaneously gentle yet firm. He will suggest that you step off the dais and sit among one of the many small tables, but the choice is yours.

The table is small and round, the kind that one finds outside a café. He will take a genuine interest in your affairs; will laugh only at a good joke, and otherwise rib you toothlessly until you find in that its own humor; surprise you with noble comments and thoughtful insights. You notice that he does not look away when he speaks, but that his eyes are never piercing.

The princes are generally great judges of character, and should he find you to be curious and sincere—the prince despises sycophants, although heartfelt flattery will open many doors—he will move towards deeper conversation. "But come now," he will say, "you must have many

questions." This is an opportunity to ask whatever you like, for the prince will answer all. Avoid, if you can, discussing the other princes.

If you ask him why people take up positions within his princedom, the prince will bend forwards with a knowing smile. A prince must court the innermost desires of his subjects if he is to maintain his position, he explains. He has already given his courtiers everything. Therefore, he must bargain with promises of self-actualization. He adopts the position of the other, what is outside the self, what could be.

And if you fail, you might ask then. His look is frank. The wars between the princes are a social game, the courtiers are pieces, and the moves are luxury and expectation. Diplomacy is at best intrigue, as the princes often backstab and betray, conspire, and conspire to conspire. Pressing his hands together, he explains that princes who fail to do so are vulnerable to the encroaching of an opportunistic rival, and are ultimately subsumed.

If you admit, finally, that you find it difficult to reconcile his seeming frankness, intelligence, even tenderness, with the boundless abandon that orbits his person, the prince will laugh. You might go on to say how, in your culture, temperance in all of its forms is a virtue. He will explain then, finally, how the prince and his many aspirants believe that in order to attain true self-actualization, one must pursue bliss in its many forms, be able to indulge in deepest desire without losing the self. Directing your attention to the hall, he tells you that strife and joy are tightly coupled. The festivities teach the courtiers to overcome their automatic responses to stimuli and assert their right to self-governance. To attain enlightenment, one must be able to contain within themselves all things.

Getting up, he encourages you to ring a silver bell near the back of the hall, which has etched on it the word *feast*. The wooden handle is cool in your palm, and as you ring it, the bell lets out a purifying chime. Almost immediately, a procession of buffet carts pushed by many men supply each table with unique, individualized meals, which they set down next to special name placards. Yours has your name on it, spelt perfectly, and embossed in recycled driftwood. A waiter serves you from your left, placing the plate before your chin so that the steam buffets the front of your face. Rare fruits and cheeses are arranged tastefully around your plate. In its center, a pig leg glistens in its own juices. When you, mouth-watering, skewer the first mouthful and lift it to your face: the lesson is revealed.

Each bite, is, on its own, unpalatable, and attendants regularly place buckets next to the diners to encourage them to vomit. However, once finished, the conquest of the meal imparts a feeling of divine completeness. As you wipe your mouth, the prince smiles. “Deeper than hearing the truth,” he remarks, “you have now tasted it.” In this way, the Border Princes teach their people the satisfaction that exists obscured by effort.

And with this, the prince shall turn to you, and ask the question he asks us all. “And you?” Each word, syllable, breath, is measured. “Will you choose to stay?” To this, only you can answer. But be mindful of this: you can come back, decide to stay, or leave, but you will never make the same choice as this.

There is one last thing to discuss—as you return, slowly, but inevitably, to the shower—that I would be remiss to leave out. A truly bizarre sight. There is a tradition among the courtiers, possibly older than the princes (I know not how) who for their part disapprove, although like all things, do not forbid it. It is a tradition with which I am intimately familiar.

A courtier who has had their heart set on it—which now, I rather reluctantly, will admit to having been—and cannot be deterred, is taken to the only room in the palace without decorations. At the time I had recently lost my wife, and soon after had thrown myself into the exercises. Briefly I was a courtier, but that was not enough. It was a long time ago.

I waited, shivering in the dark, with four other aspirants: a servant, a musician, a minister of culture, and a jester. Only the jester had not chosen to be there, having chosen this to escape execution. The servants affixed a belt around my waist. The belt was flat and leather, except a circular candleholder which protruded below the bellybutton, and a small pouch to the right which stored a tin oiling can. The prince was there to oversee us all. He placed the candlesticks on each holder himself, and then promised that if we could keep the wick alight for the length of the candle, that he would grant us one wish—anything we desired. My prince was stout and puckish. He looked sad. I did not need to say to him what I wished. There was not a day I did not miss my wife, then.

Solemnly, he told us the rules: The candle must burn for at least ten long years—extinguish too soon, and the aspirant will have failed. The candle flame must burn continuously and without interruption, it cannot go out. The belt is magic and cannot come off until the candle has completely burnt through.

We left the room with a feeling of giddy camaraderie, chatting amongst ourselves. We were allowed to return to our normal lives of revelry, but we quickly discovered that the flame was temperamental and required constant attention. Slowly, I learned the best way to cup my hands around the flame, shielding it from errant breezes.

Within the month, the musician's flame was the first to go. Unwilling to do without his instrument, he had continued to play in the Great Hall, where some carefree drunk had knocked him over, extinguishing his light. After that, we stopped attending the riotous parties. During festivals, we gathered with the other candle-bearers within disused tool rooms, or in the corners of empty halls, lighting the dark like a sea of fireflies.

After several long years, the servant died. By this point, we only discussed matters relating to our candles. We would fret over whether we'd juiced the wick with too much oil; we would fret when the wick looked dry, and diminish with the waning flame. During these discussions, the servant would not speak. When we would ask him his thoughts, he would call us foolish for sharing our secrets, that he had found the right way to go about it but would not share. We found him in his room. Having been too impatient with the wick, he had juiced it too much. Over time the flame had seared his belly, and he was dead.

Others, outside our group, died before their candles went out. On the fifth year, we had stopped talking entirely, but still kept each other's company. We would wander through the lavish hallways, rest beneath staircases, heads bent in singular focus, whispering to the flame, caressing the edges of its warmth. One night, the minister of culture, unthinking, rolled over while sleeping, snuffing out his flame. He and the jester had remained especially close; they were the only two who still talked. At the sight of him being carried away, the jester was driven instantly mad.

In the seventh year, I could take no more. I had stopped taking the ointment they gave us for belt rash. When I closed my eyes, I could see the brilliant shimmer of the flame pressed into the dark, so that I could no longer look away. Four months stretched between when I decided to let go before I finally gave up. One night, I woke up to a searing heat. The candleflame had

begun to burn my belly and I was terrified that, like the servant before me, I too might die. But still I only knew the candle, thought only in terms of breeze and heat. Panicked, I doused the wick in oil and the whole thing went up at once. The candle had melted. I still have the scars from the wax, but I was otherwise alive.

The punishment for failure is severe. It is not to be condemned to rot away in the dungeons or hung on the gallows, for there are none. In fact, there is no judicial system, nor are there courtrooms, or jails, in a single province in all of the Border Prince territories. I was sentenced alongside all of those found breaking the law, which are singularly few: murder without consent, conspiring with another prince, gross acts of violence or debauchery. We were cast out of the border prince's fiefdom; our names stricken from the book in black-ink; excommunicated, we were never permitted to return again. The reason follows from the principles that govern the princes' rule: to be made to leave in such a manner, not of one's own volition and waning desire, but against one's own will, stains the consciousness in perpetuity. To prevent another from attaining something, as opposed to them denying that thing themselves, is effectively equivalent to unrecognizing someone as conscious by revoking their agency. Attain self-fulfillment, or despair and wail, the excommunicated has had the walls of possibility closed in on them.

Unpersoned, many cannot cope. They wander along the rolling walkways, a black mark trailing their conscience like a stray dog. Slowly driven mad by the prospect of a banded universe, they will take up posts along the crossroads, howling like grief-stricken banshees, waiting for travelers so that they can return to the beginning of their tragic tale.